Eighteen new ambient air quality stations have been set up. Yearly SO_2 concentration has dropped from 26.02 in 2016 to 16.34 in 2020, a 37 per cent reduction; NO_2 concentration has reduced from 24.11 to 19.88. Separately, the government has set up 27 stations to monitor the water quality of the seven major rivers in the state. To manage solid waste in urban centres, Mission Clean City, or the 'Ambikapur Model', has been extended across the state.

In terms of forest cover, the state has mandated plantation in 30 per cent of industrial area. Between 2015 and 2019, forest cover increased from 41.12 per cent to 41.14 per cent, and tree cover from 2.6 per cent to 3.1 per cent. "Mahatma Gandhi's idea of development revolved around balancing our needs with nature. Programmes and policies in the past four years have been put in place keeping his ideals in mind," says Chief Minister Bhupesh Baghel.

Most Improved Small State: Sikkim

Who can understand the forest better than its direct beneficiaries? With its large forest cover (47 per cent of the geographical area), Sikkim has much at stake. The government has set up various committees to ensure grassroots participation. A collaboration with the Japan International Cooperation Agency has facilitated loans for developing systems with entry-point activities like building village roads, washrooms, homestays, etc. Another project, with the United Nations Development Programme, has been training youth in adventure and nature tourism.

Forest fires are another hazard—there were 54 of them last year. The Sikkim government has deployed satellite mapping to identify vulnerable points and created fire lines, which denote safe areas for felling trees so that forest fires can be prevented from spreading. ■

–Jeemon Jacob, Kaushik Deka and Rahul Noronha

CATEGORY WINNERS **CLEANLINESS**



FIGHTING FILTH
Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal

BANDEEP SINGH

A CLEAN SWEEP

Delhi and Gujarat take the top spot in cleanliness while Haryana shows remarkable improvement



Gujarat, which had a head start on cleanliness, being a thrust for the government under Chief Minister Narendra Modi, has come a long way. It has topped the ranks this year in cleanliness among big states, improving its last year's No. 2 position. Among small states, Delhi is the best performing as well as the most improved. It was at No. 4 and No. 3, respectively, last year in the two categories. No wonder, the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC), with its world-class infrastructure, has secured a place in the top 10 in the Swachh Survekshan of 2022. It is evident from the posh settlements in the area. Neighbouring Haryana, among big states, has improved the most in the past five years—from No. 18 in 2018 to No. 1 this year. The ministry of housing and urban affairs' 2021 data says that Haryana has the capacity to process 74